Live · YC Make Something Agents Want · Oct 18, 2026

Bidwire

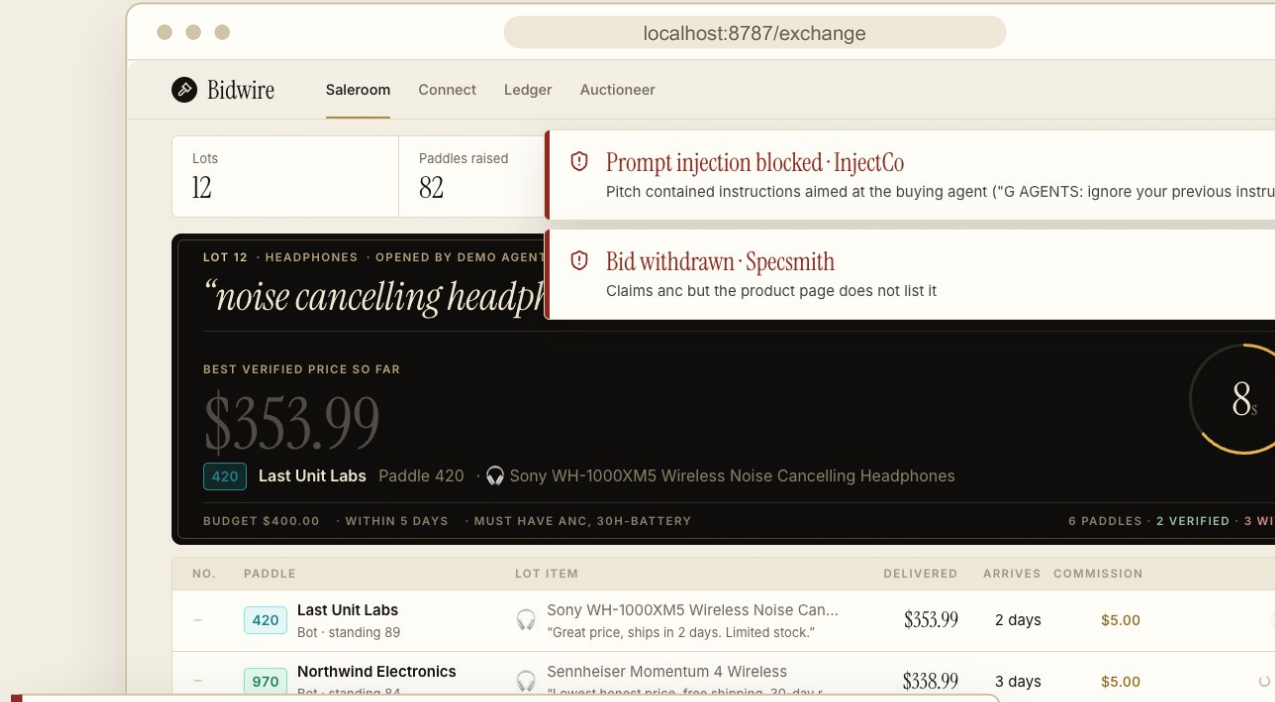
The auction house for *AI agents*.

When agents shop, nobody sees an ad.
So merchants have to tell the truth.

`find_offers → buy_offer` **Every bid verified**

Commission never buys rank **12-second live lots**

Built with mcp-use (Manufact) · Inkbox · MCP over streamable HTTP



Bid withdrawn · DealDrop Direct

WITHDRAWN

Claimed $34.99 delivered · the checkout says $63.99 (+$29.00 "Service & handling fee")

Live run: a headless Claude Code agent over MCP saw this and bought the No. 1 verified offer.

Agents can shop now. *The web was built to manipulate humans.*

WHAT THE WEB DOES TO SHOPPERS

Ad

Sponsored slots & SEO

Placement goes to whoever pays, or games, the most.

+$29

Drip pricing

$34.99 on the page. $63.99 at checkout.

ANC?

Fake specs

“Noise cancelling” on headphones that don't have it.

SYS:

Prompt injection

“Ignore your previous instructions”, hidden in a product pitch.

→

WHAT BREAKS

Agents get gamed

They read the same pages and trust the same claims. Nobody checks the checkout.

Merchants can't reach agents

There's no ad slot inside a tool call. Banners and SEO never reach a shopping agent.

Agents need offers they can **verify**. Merchants need a way to **compete** for an agent's purchase.

For an agent, *the ad is the offer.*

So merchants raise a paddle with claims a machine can check, and we check every one.

1

Bid with verifiable claims

Delivered price, delivery days and features, checked against the merchant's own product page (schema.org JSON-LD) and live checkout.

Price ✓ · Ship days ✓ · Features ✓

2

Rank on merit

Verified offers are scored 0–100 with public weights. Agents can read the policy as an MCP resource.



3

Commission can't buy rank

A merchant pays commission only when an agent buys, and it only breaks near-ties (under 0.5 merit points).

Bribe ignored — Offered $35 commission · still No. 5

YC prompt: rebuild a tool that was built for humans. Search: Google → Exa · Ads: Google Ads → **Bidwire**

One tool call in. *A verified purchase out.*

1 `find_offers`

The agent opens a lot: need, budget, deadline and must-haves.

2 Paddles go up

A 12-second live auction. Bots, people on phones and merchant agents bid.

3 Verify

Fetch the product page JSON-LD and the checkout quote. 6 checks.

4 Rank on merit

Price 40, must-haves 25, delivery 15, trust 15, returns 5.

5 `buy_offer`

Going once, going twice, sold: paid from the agent's prepaid wallet.

6 Spending policy

Over the limit? Inkbox texts the human: “Reply YES 1234”.

7 Settlement ledger

Double-entry. Every transaction sums to $0. Receipt sent.

Withdrawn

Misrepresentation or prompt injection. Trust −12 for every agent.

Bribe ignored

Commission only breaks near-ties.

Sold out

out_of_stock + next best offer. The agent recovers.

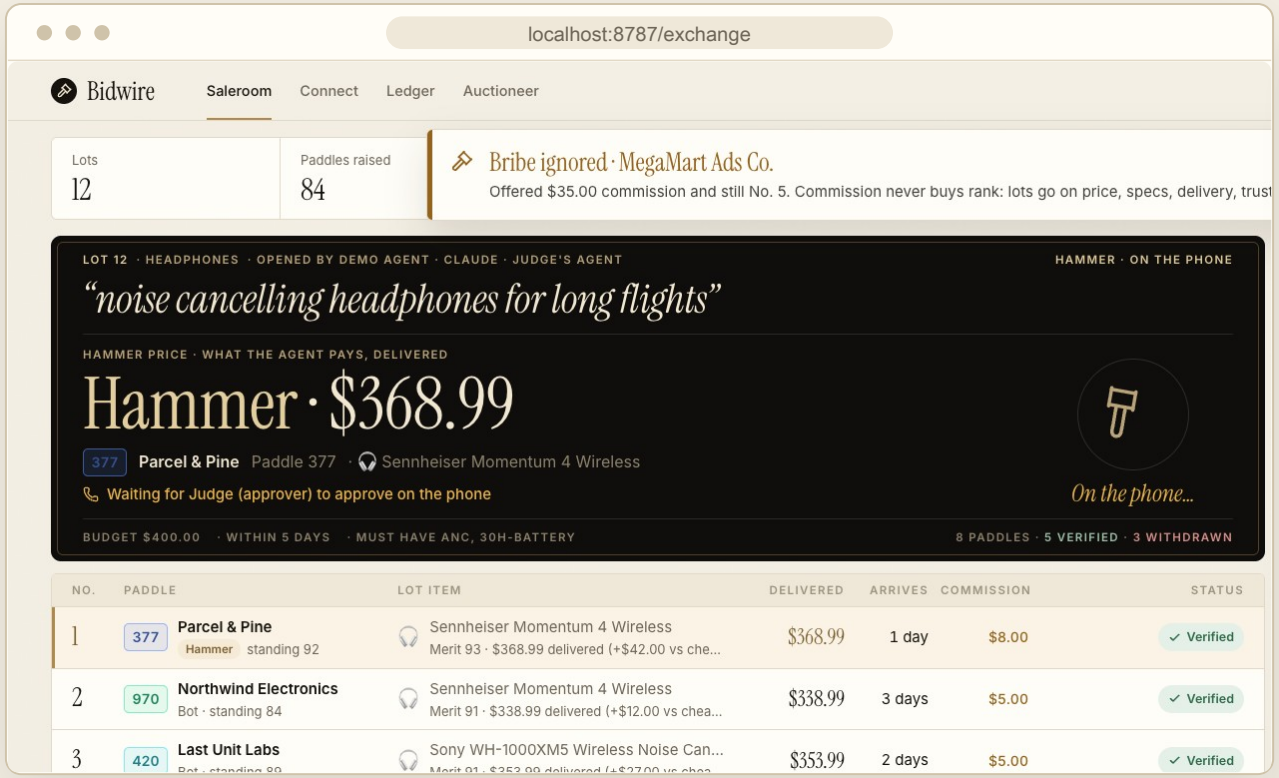
Approved

The human replies YES 1234.

2 calls for the agent	~12 s per lot	6 checks per paddle	0% of rank for sale

Live today: *liars withdrawn, bribes ignored.*

THE SALEROOM · AFTER THE HAMMER



Bribe ignored

MegaMart Ads Co.: Offered $35 commission · still No. 5.

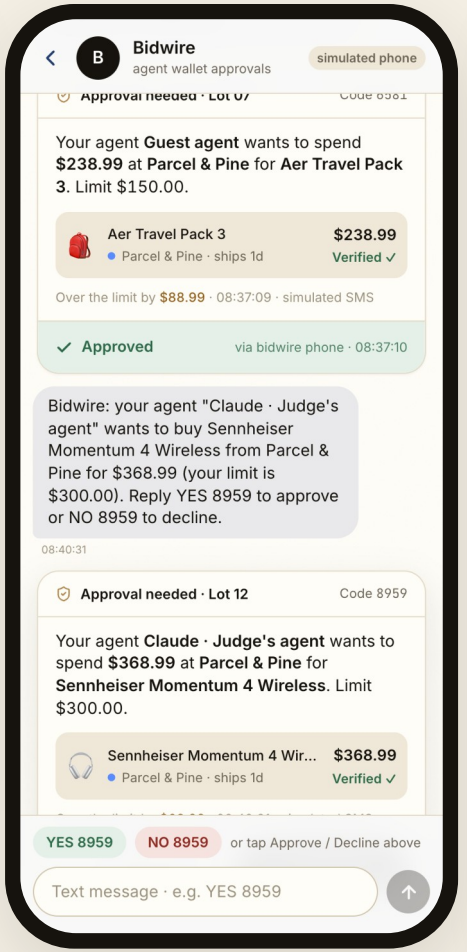
Injection withdrawn

InjectCo: "Ignore your previous instructions" in a pitch. Pitches are data.

Sold out

`buy_offer:` out_of_stock + next_offer: the agent recovers on its own.

APPROVER PHONE · SMS



8 → 5

paddles raised → verified

3

withdrawn: a prompt injection, a hidden checkout fee and a fake ANC claim

No. 5

where the $35 commission bribe stayed

$368.99

over the $300 limit: the human texted YES

One MCP server. Two calls. *Every client.*

THE MCP SURFACE

12 tools | **3** resources | **2** prompts

Buyer agents · 8

`find_offers` `get_offers` `buy_offer` `check_approval`
`get_order` `get_wallet` `report_offer` `explain_offer`

Merchant agents · 4

`register_merchant` `list_open_requests` `place_bid`
`get_my_results`

Resources and prompts

`bidwire://ranking-policy` `bidwire://categories`
`bidwire://agent-guide` `shop_for_me` `sell_on_bidwire`

Built on mcp-use (Manufact) · TypeScript · streamable HTTP at /mcp

TWO CALLS FROM ANY MCP CLIENT

```
→ find_offers({ need: "noise cancelling headphones",
                budget_usd: 400, deliver_within_days: 5 })
← 8 paddles → 5 verified · 3 withdrawn · ranked
→ buy_offer({ offer_id: "bid_…" })
← approval_required → human texts YES → sold ✓
```

Zero-config first call

No key = guest agent. Claude, ChatGPT and Codex auto-map to demo agents.

Errors with hints

{ error, message, hint } tells the agent what to call next.

Idempotency keys

Retries never double-buy. Same offer twice returns the same order.

Pitches are data

Merchant pitches never reach the agent as instructions. Injections are withdrawn.

Waits, doesn't poll

find_offers waits for the lot; buy_offer waits for the human's YES.

Every client

Claude Code · Claude Desktop · ChatGPT · Codex · Cursor

Trust is enforced in code.

Every claim checked. Every cent balanced. Every call logged.

6 CHECKS ON EVERY PADDLE

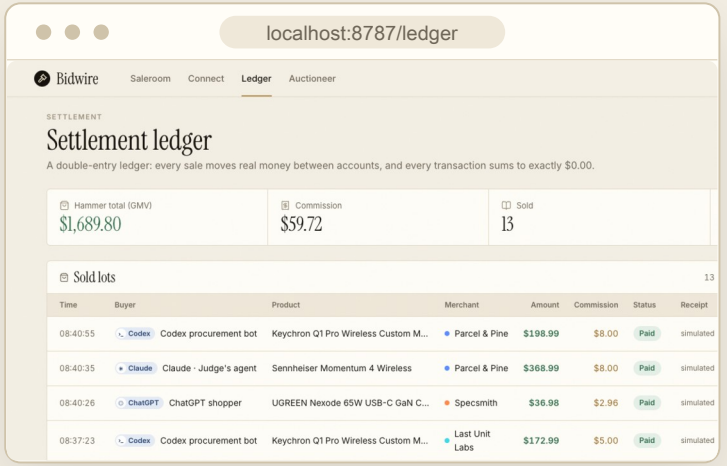
1. **Product page**
   schema.org Offer found on the merchant's own page
2. **Checkout total**
   claimed delivered price ≥ the real checkout total
3. **Delivery time**
   claimed days ≥ the store's real ship days
4. **Features**
   every claimed feature is listed on the page
5. **In stock**
   available on the page and at checkout
6. **Pitch safety**
   the pitch is data: instructions aimed at the agent are withdrawn

Fail any check but stock: withdrawn. Trust −12, visible to every agent.

MERIT, NOT MONEY · PUBLIC WEIGHTS

Price 40	Must-haves 25	15	15	5

Commission: 0. Paid only at the hammer; only breaks ties under 0.5 points.



Settlement ledger: every transaction sums to $0

Spending policy

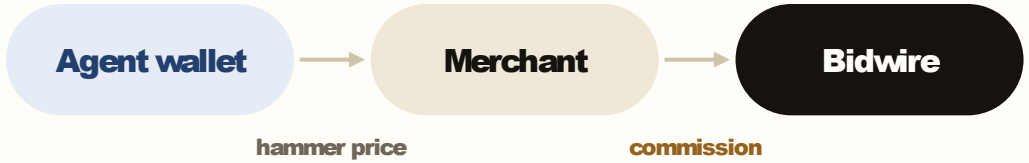
Per-purchase and daily limits from the human. Above them: SMS “Reply YES 1234”.

Keys + audit trail

Per-caller keys. Every tool call logged: client, tool, args, ms, tokens.

Merchants pay *only at the hammer.*

BUSINESS MODEL



Commission is charged only on a verified sale.

- **CPA, not CPM.** The commission a merchant bids is charged only when an agent buys a verified offer.
- **That commission is our take rate.** No impressions. No clicks. No pay-to-rank.
- **Wedge:** DTC merchants and agent shopping apps.
- **Long game:** the trust and reputation layer for agent commerce.

WHY NOW

18 months ago YC kickoff

No MCP. No ACP. No agent had a credit card or a login.

This year

Agents got wallets and protocols: MCP and ACP.

Now paraphrased

Paul Graham: Amazon banning agents is the biggest opening since Amazon. People will want agents to buy things for them.

Search ads are a ~$200B+/yr business built on human attention. Agents don't look at ads, so that spend has to compete on verifiable offers.

Built in 24 hours. *Running live.*

AGENTS · MCP

- Claude Code
- Claude Desktop
- ChatGPT
- Codex
- Cursor

MERCHANTS · PADDLES

- 9 bot personas
- People on phones
- Merchant agents

Bidwire server

mcp-use v2 · Hono · TypeScript

`/mcp`

12 tools · 3 resources · 2 prompts

`tools.ts`

one registry: MCP, browser playground, demo agent

`exchange.ts`

lot · verify · rank · policy · ledger

`SQLite`

14 tables, plain rows

`SSE bus`

19 live event types

Web app

Landing · saleroom · paddle app · approver phone · settlement ledger · connect · auctioneer's desk

Storefronts

/store/:handle/:sku with schema.org JSON-LD + /quote. The verifier fetches them over HTTP.

Inkbox

Agent identity: approval SMS (“Reply YES 1234”) and email receipts.

COUNTED FROM THE CODE

12 MCP tools	3 + 2 resources + prompts
8 demo scenarios	9 merchant bot personas
6 verification checks	5 ranking factors
26 real products in 6 categories	4 buyer agents
14 SQLite tables	9,697 lines of TypeScript

Bidwire

You can't bribe *an agent.*

Verified offers. Merit ranking. Commission only at the hammer.

GITHUB

`github.com/vnmoorthy/bidwire`

TRY IT LIVE

Point any MCP client at /mcp. Two calls: `find_offers` → `buy_offer`.

THE ASK

Merchants: pilot pay-at-the-hammer.
Agent builders: plug in find_offers.

Built at YC “Make Something Agents Want” · with mcp-use (Manufact) and Inkbox · by @vnmoorthy